WEST BENGAL

UNIONS OF PATRONAGE

By Romita Datta



BEFORE TRAGEDY STRUCK
KK performing at a concert

PTI

College unions in West Bengal have long been mired in games of political control and are fields where inter-party rivalries play out viciously. Now, the tragic death of singer KK (Krishnakumar Kunnath) after a performance at a college fest on May 31 has thrown the spotlight on things other than the gross mismanagement being blamed for his demise. Indeed, such brazen negligence—at the 2,700-capacity Nazrul Mancha auditorium where the event took place, over 7,000 people were packed in, stopping the air-conditioning and generating unbearable heat—is linked with the very nature of how the unions operate. Over everything else are the huge funds unions have at their disposal and the clout they allegedly wield over the college administrations.

Election for college unions under Calcutta University (CU) was last held in 2017. With the term for each union being one year, fresh polls were due in 2018. However, the Trinamool Congress regime has been dragging its feet over it—one reason is the fear of losing the stranglehold they now have over the unions. The other is because it wants to replace elected unions by a nominated students' council—where members would be appointed by college governing bodies—in the long run. Governing bodies are said to be dominated by the TMC. Out of 150 state sponsored/ aided colleges under CU, only one has a Left affiliated union; most are run by the TMC.

Power and money are the reasons why stakes are so high in controlling the unions. For fests, they are known to spend anywhere between Rs 20 and Rs 25 lakh, nearly matching the annual budget itself of some colleges. Unions are allowed a union charge from each student, which comes to Rs 5-8 lakh annually, and is factored in the college fee. About the rest, authorities are kept in the dark. According to Students' Federation of India leader Debanjan Dey, they come from "illegal practices", like the sale of seats. "In pre-digital days, unions had supreme control over admission.... The cost of a seat in Geography (Hons) in a city college varied between Rs 1 lakh and Rs 1.2 lakh, and seats for Science subjects cost between Rs 50,000 and Rs 70,000," Dey adds. With online admissions, unions allegedly sell unutilised seats from the second/ third lists at exorbitant prices. Students admitted thus are required to pay up for various college events, even allegedly for celebrating the birthdays of local (TMC) leaders.

Unions mobilise funds—'extra' tickets at the KK concert were allegedly sold for as much as Rs 3,000—a portion of which is said to feed a section of the TMC (college unions also promote the party). "College is the best ground for indoctrinating young minds. The ruling party is making full use of it by pushing its leaders in governing bodies, and as guests of honour and speakers in programmes. A fest brought in Nikhita Gandhi as a star performer, but TMC leaders in attendance gave such long speeches that the singer was left with no time to sing," says a student from a central Kolkata college.

"The source of huge budgets for fests is a mystery. Local political leaders control the colleges under their jurisdiction. Often principals succumb to pressure," says Subhodoy Dasgupta, president of the left-leaning West Bengal College and University Teachers' Association.

POWER AND MONEY ARE REASONS WHY STAKES ARE HIGH IN THE CONTROL OF UNIONS

Chief minister Mamata Banerjee is now talking about imposing strictures on unions, like curbing extravagant spending. But with college unions flouting rules with impunity for so long, it will be a tall ask. ■